

How far does digital media help to facilitate health prevention behaviour and sustainable lifestyle change?

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Abstract

Preventive healthcare is more important in the world than ever before, and the strain of chronic diseases upon the health care system. Meanwhile, digital media technologies have changed the way that people seek health information, track their own behaviors and interact with health communities. In this paper the potential for digital media in supporting the adoption of preventive health behaviour and changing sustainable lifestyle is discussed. It is based on the latest academic research and includes 4 areas of the use of digital technologies: access to information, self monitoring, social support and personalised interventions. The essay also critically reviews socio-cultural issues affecting digital health technologies such as misinformation, privacy, algorithmic influence and digital inequality. The authors advocate the promise of digital media in prevention health behavior, but contend that a prerequisite is equitable access to digital media, ethical design, and that evidence-based health behavior is integrated into digital media. All in all, digital media can be a useful tool to help facilitate health behaviour change, but should not be used in place of a health care professional.

1. Introduction

Preventive health care is a health care whose purpose is to prevent disease. Some of the most common preventative measures are health screening, healthy eating, stress management, regularly exercising, and getting enough sleep. The World Health Organization (WHO) has established a list of many lifestyle behaviours with strong links to many chronic diseases, including cardiovascular diseases, type 2 diabetes and some cancers.

In recent years, digital media has become a central aspect of people's everyday life. The smartphone, wearable fitness trackers and social media platforms and health apps represent new avenues for people to access health information and track their behaviours. These are technologies that are one step away from traditional health communication strategies.

Research Question: What are the potential of digital media to encourage health promotion behaviours and facilitate lifestyle change?

2. Digital Media and Health Information

One of the best advantages of electronic media within the realm of prevention health care is that it's improved the accessibility to health information. Digital platforms are a way for individuals to access information anywhere, from any device at any time on nutrition, exercise, disease prevention and mental wellbeing.

Digital health interventions have demonstrated effects on positive health behaviors which lead to improved health prevention, such as health awareness and informed decision making (Duan et al. 2021). Those who are actively seeking health information online are more likely to be engaged in preventive activities, like participating in exercise, improving their diet and health screening activities.

But misinformation can spread quickly via social media. Chatterjee et al. (2021) emphasizes how important credibility of information is for a digital health intervention being effective. Digital Literacy is an important aspect of preventive health care.

3. Self Monitoring and Behavioural Awareness

Digitalisation of the media has also led to new ways of delivering health and care, such as the use of technology for self monitoring in preventive health care. Body sensors can be used in conjunction with smart phone applications to track physical activity, sleep, calorie intake and other health indicators.

Patel et al (2019) suggest that wearables do not directly, but indirectly, impact behaviour change. While technology may support us, we must be motivated, accountable and self-regulated.

But there can be negative effects of too much self-tracking. People may feel anxious if they aren't achieving their health goals. Therefore, self monitoring technologies are considered supporting technologies.

4. Social Media and Online Communities and Social support

Social environments, as well as individual motivation, have an impact on preventive health behaviours. Digital media can be used to establish a community online for people to share their experiences, encouragement and health related knowledge.

According to Naslund et al. (2020) peer-to-peer support is one of the most appreciated features of digital health settings. Internet forums can be an additional form of emotional support.

But social media can also bring pressure through idealized healthy lifestyles and unrealistic comparisons, which may negatively affect self-esteem.

5. Personalisation and Digital Health Interventions

One of the latest innovations in digital health technologies is personalisation. Many health apps use behaviour information to offer personalised ideas, reminders and objectives.

Tong et al. (2021) noticed that personalised mobile health technologies are more effective than generic interventions. Personalized recommendations are more relevant to individual needs.

However, ethics and privacy issues arise when collecting personal health data. Personalisation without compromising privacy remains a real challenge.

6. Socio-Cultural Challenges & Limitations

Digital divide is a significant problem. Older people, lower-income groups and those with low digital literacy may face barriers to digital health resources.

Algorithmic influence is another issue. Platforms recommend content based on algorithms, which are often “black boxes” to users.

Privacy is also a key concern. The collection and analysis of personal health data create tensions between innovation and individual rights.

7. Conclusion

Digital Media is a great way to convey preventive health behaviours and sustainable lifestyle changes. Digital platforms open up opportunities through information access, self-monitoring, social support and personalised interventions.

Challenges include misinformation, privacy issues, algorithmic influence, and digital inequality. No technology can replace professional health care.

With evidence-based practices, ethical design and inclusive access, digital media can best support public health. Balancing innovation and social needs is essential.

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